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From the editor-in-chief

The spectre of terrorism, the chaos of global recession, the threat of climate change. The last few years have seemed tough times for a world hit by one crisis after another. For the first time in many months, this passing year though seemed to bring the beginnings of some good news, especially in India. Dramatic turnarounds are always rare but it is fair to suggest that 2009 has marked the first signs of recovery for our country, particularly in the place which affects people of every class the most: their pockets. In 2008, we had great economic gloom, rising unemployment, inflation touching double digits, the stock exchange hitting its lowest in five years and general pessimism around industrial growth. But this year, the Indian economy has proved that its survival—and revival—instincts are fairly strong.

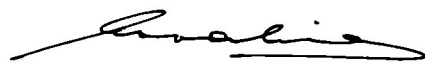
A lot of this has to do with the oldest and often-unheralded footsoldier of India's economy: its rural sector. The push given by way of debt waivers and higher procurement prices to farmers and social development schemes enabled millions in rural areas to turn from merely modest-income earners to consumers. This gave the urban economy a boost, so much so that the last quarter saw economic growth rise from 6 to 7.9 per cent, a figure that the Government hopes will end up reflecting the year's overall numbers. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh believes it will take India a year or two to return to its previous 9 per cent growth. It will take a lot more effort for that to happen, but that seems to be an appropriate goal to aim for in a new year.

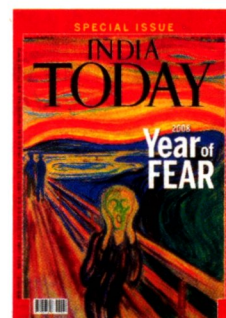
Even outside the world of business, 2009 would be a year of revival in the Prime Minister's Office and the Congress, given the results of the general elections this year. Rarely do Indian governments retain their mandate like the UPA did and of course, they did gloat. It has to be said, though, that 2009 also marked the slow fading away of the alternative ideology in Indian politics. We saw the withering away of all vibrant and vigilant opposition at the Centre and in the states. This is a phenomenon which only reflects that our political class seems to be less focused on issues that matter and more on the means needed to regain power these days.

Other than politics, there seems to be a burst of progress and transformation in other fields. In cinema, our audiences rejected noisy, big-budget releases for better told stories. In sport, the controversies over the Commonwealth Games extravaganza was edged aside by the global achievements of a bunch of new athletes.

Our year-end issue is a glimpse of the highlights of what has generally been a buoyant year across all fields. Other than economic matters, the best news India could have had all year was to actually not have the kind of news that showed up constantly in 2008—about a terrorist attack in our cities. This could have been the direct aftermath of the horrors of 26/11 or even pure chance, but we certainly needed to feel more secure in our cities. In that sense, 2009 was a flicker of hope. May it continue.

On this note of optimism, I wish our readers a happy, safe and successful new year.


(Aroon Purie)



OUR JANUARY
2009 COVER